DIGITALAIKART · INDIA

The Indian Exporter's Paperwork Playbook 2026-27

From IEC to money in the bank: the shipping bill, GST refund, RoDTEP and realisation sequence for small exporters

22 chapters · 5 printable worksheets · one worked consignment · every rule sourced

Written against DGFT notifications, CBIC circulars, GST rules and the FEMA (Export and Import of Goods and Services) Regulations, 2026 as they stand in November 2026.

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What this playbook does

An export does not fail at the port. It fails three weeks earlier, in a spreadsheet, when one field on a shipping bill disagrees with one line on a GST return. By the time the container is at Nhava Sheva or the parcel is at the airport, the mistake is already expensive: an amendment needs an officer, a refund needs a re-match, and an incentive quietly disappears.

This playbook is the paperwork half of exporting from India. Not Incoterms theory, not market research, not how to find buyers. It is the sequence of documents, declarations, returns and follow-ups that stand between a confirmed order and money in your bank account, written against the rules as they stand in November 2026.

The single most useful thing in this book
Every fact here is tied to a document you can open yourself: a DGFT notification number, a CBIC circular, an RBI regulation, a GST rule. Where a rule changed in 2026, the old position is named too, because half the advice on the internet still quotes it.

Who this is written for

Small and first-time exporters: a manufacturer shipping his first container, a proprietor selling on Amazon Global Selling, a craft business sending courier parcels, a trading house doing merchant exports, a service firm invoicing overseas clients. If your exports are under roughly Rs. 10 crore a year and you do not have a full-time compliance team, this is your book.

It assumes you already have a buyer and a product. It assumes nothing about your knowledge of customs, GST or FEMA.

The cost of getting this wrong is measurable

Reporting in early 2026 put numbers on the paperwork problem. The Economic Times, quoting the Federation of Indian Export Organisations, reported GST refund delays blocking an estimated Rs. 25,000 to 30,000 crore of MSME working capital a year, with refund cycles stretching to six to nine months against a global benchmark of 30 to 45 days. Laghu Udyog Bharti put licensing and compliance delays at 10 to 15 days per operation, against under four days for competitors abroad. The Federation of Indian Micro and Small and Medium Enterprises estimated that almost one-fifth of an exporter's time still goes on manual compliance.

A payments platform serving more than 25,000 exporters reported the per-transaction version of the same problem: exporters losing days of productivity and roughly Rs. 3,000 to 5,000 on every USD 10,000 of payment, chasing banks for realisation certificates.

None of that is about tariffs or shipping rates. All of it is paperwork. Which means all of it is fixable by knowing the sequence.

How to use it

1. If you are shipping for the first time, read Parts 1 to 3 in order before you file anything. They are the setup: identity, classification, customs, GST.

2. If you already ship and money is stuck, go straight to Part 5 on realisation and eBRC, then Part 3 on refunds.
3. If you are choosing between the LUT route and the IGST route, read Chapter 7 twice. It is the one decision in this book that changes your cash flow for the whole year.
4. Use the worksheets at the back as working documents. Print them, or keep them as a tab in your sheet.

Currency convention: figures are in Indian rupees unless marked USD. Rates, fees and thresholds are those notified as of November 2026 and are stated with their source so you can check for later amendments.

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PART 1

Identity: the four registrations that come before any shipment

Four things must exist before your first shipping bill can be accepted: an IEC, a GST registration with the right export setup, an AD code registered at the port you are using, and a bank account in the name of the IEC holder. Three of the four are free or nearly free. All four are things people discover are wrong only when a shipment is held.

1. The document set, in the order it is actually needed

Most exporters think of documents as a pile. They are a sequence, and each one depends on the one before it. Get the sequence right and the pile assembles itself.

#	Document	Who issues it	What it unlocks
1	PAN of the entity	Income Tax Dept	Everything below
2	GST registration	GSTN	Tax invoice, LUT, refunds
3	IEC	DGFT, online, Rs. 500	Customs will accept a shipping bill
4	AD code letter	Your bank branch	Port registration; EDPMS routing
5	RCMC (if your product needs one)	Export Promotion Council	Scheme benefits above Rs. 3 lakh FOB
6	LUT, or a decision to pay IGST	GST portal (RFD-11)	Zero-rated supply without cash outflow
7	Export invoice and packing list	You	The commercial record, GST and customs
8	Shipping bill	Filed by you or your broker on ICEGATE	Customs clearance; the refund claim
9	Bill of lading or airway bill	Carrier or forwarder	Title, and the EGM

Two of these are one-time. Two renew every year. The rest are per shipment. The annual ones - IEC updation and the LUT - are where small exporters get caught, because nothing reminds you and the failure is silent until a filing bounces.

The nine documents that travel with every consignment

For customs purposes, the mandatory set is short. The list notified by DGFT in notification 08/2015-20, and still used by the e-Sanchit system, names the bill of lading or airway bill, the commercial invoice, and the packing list - a combined commercial invoice cum packing list is accepted. Everything else is product-specific: a certificate of origin, a phytosanitary certificate, a test report, a SCOMET licence, an Advance Authorisation.

That short list is why so many first shipments fail: the mandatory set is not the complete set. The complete set for your product is defined by its HS code, its destination, and the scheme you are claiming. Three sources tell you: the ITC(HS) export policy entry, the destination country's import requirements, and your export promotion council.

> **Rule of thumb**
> If a document is not in the e-Sanchit upload, customs cannot see it. Uploading is not the same as attaching: the IRN generated at upload must be quoted in the shipping bill itself. Documents uploaded but not tagged are, for practical purposes, documents that do not exist.

e-Sanchit: where documents actually live

Customs does not collect paper files for exports any more. Supporting documents are uploaded to e-Sanchit inside ICEGATE by a registered user with a digital signature certificate. Each upload returns an Image Reference Number, or IRN. That IRN is then quoted against the item in the shipping bill, along with a document type code.

- Only PDF is accepted, and the file must be digitally signed by the same user who logged in.
- Individual users can upload five documents in one batch; the size limit varies by document type, from about 1 MB to 20 MB.
- One document should be one file, however many pages it runs to.
- A document added after filing must be attached to the shipping bill by an amendment - uploading alone does not attach it.

The practical consequence: your broker needs your documents in final, signed PDF form before the shipping bill is filed, not after. Every hour of re-uploading is an hour the container sits.

2. IEC: apply once, update every year, never let it deactivate

The Importer-Exporter Code is a ten-character code issued against your PAN. It is not a licence, it does not expire, and it takes about twenty minutes to get. It is also the single most common cause of a shipment that cannot be filed, because it can be deactivated without anyone telling you.

Applying

The application is filed online in ANF-2A on dgft.gov.in. There is no paper form, no visit to a regional authority, and no physical signature. The fee is Rs. 500. The code is generated automatically and the e-IEC can be downloaded from your dashboard.

What you need in front of you:

- An active PAN in the name of the entity that will export.
- Proof of establishment: partnership deed, certificate of incorporation, trust deed, society registration, or the proprietorship's own documents.
- Address proof of the premises - sale deed, rent agreement, lease deed, electricity bill, landline or postpaid mobile bill. If the premises are not in the firm's name, add a no objection certificate from the owner in the same PDF.
- Bank proof: a cancelled cheque bearing the entity's pre-printed name, or a bank certificate in the prescribed format.
- A valid digital signature token, or Aadhaar-based authentication of a firm member.
- A mobile number and email you actually monitor - every DGFT communication goes there.

Only one IEC is issued against one PAN, and it covers all branches, divisions, units and factories of that entity. There is no separate IEC per port.

The annual obligation nobody remembers

Every IEC holder must update, or simply confirm, the IEC particulars on the DGFT portal between 1 April and 30 June each year. This applies even when nothing has changed - you still have to log in and confirm. Updation inside that window carries no fee. An IEC not updated in the window is liable to be deactivated, and a deactivated IEC stops shipments at filing.

Reactivation is not a disaster: a deactivated IEC can be activated on successful updation, without prejudice to any other action for a separate violation. But you lose the days, and you lose them at the worst moment.

The fields that most often need correcting during updation, in practice: registered address after a move, directors or partners after a change in the board, bank account details after an account is closed, and the contact email - which is where the deactivation notice goes, and which is usually an employee who has left.

Changes during the year

Any change in constitution, address, bank details or other primary particulars must be reflected in the IEC within 30 days of the change. If a merger, acquisition or inheritance produces a new PAN, a fresh IEC must be obtained against the new PAN within 30 days, and the old IEC can be operationally linked to it.

An IEC can also be surrendered online, but only once all authorisations and obligations under it are closed, or once they have transferred to the new entity.

Checking someone else's IEC

Any IEC's details can be verified on the DGFT website under View IEC Related Details. Do this before you accept a buyer's or a supplier's papers, and before you let a third party export on your behalf. Third-party exports are permitted, but both the manufacturer and the third-party exporter must appear on the shipping bill.

3. The AD code, and why your bank is part of your compliance

The Authorised Dealer code identifies the bank branch through which your export proceeds will be received. It must be registered at the specific customs port you are exporting from. A shipping bill whose AD code does not match the port registration is rejected at the filing stage - before the goods have moved.

This trips up almost every exporter who changes bank, or exports from a second port for the first time. The AD code registration is a bank-and-port pair, not a company-level setting.

- Opening a new current account for export proceeds means a new AD code letter and a fresh port registration, before the next shipping bill.
- Your bank needs the AD code letter and your IEC to set you up in EDPMS, the RBI system that tracks whether each export has been paid for.
- The AD code on the shipping bill decides which bank receives the shipping bill record in EDPMS. Get it wrong and your payment arrives at a branch that has no matching shipping bill, and the entry stays open.

What the bank is actually doing

Since 1 October 2026 the reporting framework has been consolidated into the Foreign Exchange Management (Export and Import of Goods and Services) Regulations, 2026. The practical picture for an exporter is three systems:

System	Owner	What it holds
EDPMS	RBI	Every export declared to customs, matched against inward remittances
IDPMS	RBI	Every import bill of entry, matched against outward payments
eBRC	DGFT	Your self-certified proof that a specific export was paid for

The regulations also place a duty on the authorised dealer to put systems in place to monitor and follow up with an exporter to realise proceeds within the permitted period. Your bank is not a passive mailbox; it has an obligation to chase you, and it will.

The setup checklist before your first filing

1. IEC active, and updated for the current financial year.
2. GST registration active, with the export turnover reported in the right tables.
3. AD code letter in hand, from the branch that will receive proceeds.
4. AD code registered at the port you are shipping from.
5. Current account in the exact name of the IEC holder.
6. LUT filed for the financial year, or a deliberate decision to pay IGST.
7. A named person who reads the DGFT and bank emails, and a calendar entry for 1 April.

PART 2

Classification and customs

The HS code decides your buyer's duty, your RoDTEP rate, your drawback rate, whether your product needs a licence, and whether your shipping bill is accepted at all. It is the most consequential eight digits in the entire process, and it is usually copied from the last shipment.

4. The 8-digit HS code decision

India uses the ITC-HS classification at eight digits. Four and six digit codes are a common reason for rejection on ICEGATE under current customs and GST protocols: the system cross-checks the declared code against your IEC, your AD code, your GST records and the documents your broker uploads, and a code that does not resolve to a valid eight-digit tariff item stops the filing.

The stakes are concrete. Two digits can move the duty rate your buyer pays by ten percentage points or more, which turns into a dispute, a refusal, or a penalty at the destination port. The same two digits can also move your RoDTEP rate, or drop your product out of Appendix 4R altogether.

Where to look, in order

1. The ITC(HS) export policy in the DGFT trade portal - the entry tells you whether export is free, restricted or prohibited, and what conditions attach.
2. The customs tariff at eight digits on the CBIC site - this is the code customs assesses against.
3. Appendix 4R of the RoDTEP schedule on dgft.gov.in - whether your code carries a rebate, and at what rate or cap.
4. The drawback schedule for the all-industry rate, if you claim drawback.
5. Your export promotion council, for the product-specific certificate or standard that applies.

Do this for every product, not once per business. A change in grade, processing level, packaging form or composition can move the code. A knitted cotton T-shirt and a woven cotton shirt are different chapters of decision-making even though both are 'a shirt'.

The description problem

Classification failures are usually description failures. 'Refractory material' instead of grade, type and application. 'Organic fertiliser' without type, form and packing. When the invoice says 'Stainless Steel Pipes, Grade 304, 6 Metre Length' and the packing list says 'SS Pipes Gr. 304, 6M', the automated cross-verification reads two different products and raises a query.

The fix is procedural, not clever: write the description once, in full, on the commercial invoice. Then use that exact string, without abbreviation, on the packing list, the certificate of origin and the shipping bill. Never retype it.

> **A five-minute check that prevents most rejections**
> Before filing, put the commercial invoice, the packing list and the shipping bill side by side. Compare quantity, gross and net weight, number of packages, product description and invoice value. Any difference in any of the five is a hold waiting to happen.

Classification log

Keep one row per product: the eight-digit code, the description you use everywhere, the date you verified it, the source you verified it against, and the RoDTEP and drawback position. Worksheet 5 at the back is this table. It takes ten minutes a product and it is the difference between an audit you can answer and one you cannot.

5. The shipping bill, field by field

The shipping bill is your legal declaration of export under section 50 of the Customs Act, 1962, filed electronically into the Indian Customs EDI System. Most exporters file through a customs broker licensed under the Customs Brokers Licensing Regulations, 2018. You can self-file through ICEGATE once registered, which suits regular exporters with in-house staff who understand classification and scheme codes.

Either way, you remain responsible for what is declared. A broker prepares a checklist from your documents; you approve it. Read that checklist line by line. The broker is not liable for your classification, your scheme codes or your invoice values.

The fields that matter

Field	What goes wrong
IEC and GSTIN	IEC deactivated, or GSTIN of a different unit. The system cross-checks both.
8-digit ITC(HS) code	Four or six digits, or a code copied from an older product version.
AD code	Not registered at this port, or registered against a closed account.
FOB value and currency	Declared inconsistently with the commercial invoice, or with the GST invoice.
Export route	LUT marked on the bill while the GST return says IGST paid, or the reverse.
Scheme codes	RoDTEP or drawback claimed with the wrong code, or not claimed at all.
Invoice number and date	Not identical to the GST invoice and the GSTR-1 entry.
Package count and weights	Differ between invoice, packing list and actual cargo.

The route to a let export order

1. File the shipping bill. The system generates a shipping bill number and date. You can file before the goods reach the port.
2. Assessment. The Risk Management System decides whether the bill is facilitated or sent to an officer. An officer may raise a query on value, classification or exportability.
3. Goods arrive at the port, container freight station, inland container depot or air cargo terminal - or are stuffed at your factory under self-sealing with an RFID e-seal.
4. Examination, if selected. Customs checks a sample of packages against the declaration. Factory-stuffed containers under self-sealing are generally not opened without a reason.
5. Let Export Order. Only after LEO can the goods be loaded. The final shipping bill is a digitally signed PDF with a QR code.
6. Loading, then the export general manifest filed by the shipping line or airline. This is the step that makes your refund claim real.

Documents to have ready before the broker asks

- Commercial invoice and packing list, or the combined form.
- GST tax invoice - its number and date must match what you report in GSTR-1.
- Purchase order, contract or letter of credit from the buyer.
- Any licence, authorisation or certificate the product needs.
- Bank details with the AD code letter.
- For scheme claims: the Advance Authorisation, EPCG authorisation, or the scheme reference.

Where the first filing usually breaks

Four failures account for most first-time holds. The AD code is not registered at that port. The HS code is at six digits. The invoice description differs between documents. The GST invoice number on the shipping bill is not the one filed in the return. None of these is a customs problem; all of them are your problem.

6. LEO, EGM, and the narrow door of amendment

A shipping bill becomes very hard to change at three specific moments: when the shipping bill number is generated, when the LEO is issued, and when the export general manifest is filed. Each step closes a door a little further.

The four stages of amendment

Stage	Who approves	Practical effect
Before the shipping bill number	Service centre, no approval needed	Corrections are routine
After the number, before LEO	Assistant or Deputy Commissioner (Export)	Annexure-based request with documents
After LEO	Competent authority; LEO may need cancellation	Amendment plus re-approval
After EGM	Board instructions; post-EGM module	Very restricted in practice

Section 149 of the Customs Act permits the proper officer to authorise amendment of a shipping bill, but with a proviso that bites: once the goods have been exported, an amendment can only be made on the basis of documentary evidence that was in existence at the time the goods were exported. You cannot fix a wrong declaration after the fact by creating a new document.

A post-EGM amendment module does exist in the customs system, built for amendments allowed up to two years after export under the regulations. But the Board's own letter of 13 March 2025 restricts its use, as of now, to cases complying with a court order. Treat post-EGM amendment as litigation, not administration.

What people actually need to amend

In the field, most references for amendment - including those arising from court cases - concern changing a scheme code, most often RoDTEP from 'N' to 'Y'. That is a claim you did not make at the time. It is exactly the amendment the post-EGM route makes hardest.

The lesson is blunt: the RoDTEP declaration is made when the shipping bill is filed. If it is not declared then, you are relying on an exception, not a process.

EGM: the step exporters forget

The export general manifest is filed by the carrier, not by you. Without it, your export is not complete in the systems that matter: the IGST refund under rule 96 is deemed filed only when the manifest covers the shipping bill and you have furnished a valid return, and the RoDTEP e-scrip is generated after the EGM.

If a refund is not moving, check the EGM before you file anything. It is the cheapest diagnostic in this book.

> **Three checks that resolve most stuck refunds**
> One: is the EGM filed and linked? Two: does the shipping bill's invoice number match the GSTR-1 entry exactly? Three: was IGST actually reported in table 3.1(b) of GSTR-3B, and is it at least the amount shown in tables 6A and 6B of GSTR-1?

PART 3

GST on exports

Exports are zero-rated, which does not mean untaxed. It means the entire chain is free of tax: no output tax, and input credit is refunded. Section 16 of the IGST Act, 2017 gives you two ways to get there, and the choice determines whether your money is locked in working capital for weeks or months.

7. Zero-rated supply: the two routes, and how to choose

	LUT route	IGST route
What you do	Export without paying IGST, under a bond or Letter of Undertaking	Charge and pay IGST on the invoice, then claim it back
What you claim	Refund of unutilised input tax credit	Refund of the IGST you paid
How you claim	Form GST RFD-01, with the rule 89(4) computation	No separate application - the shipping bill is the claim
Cash impact	No output tax paid at all; credit comes back later	IGST paid first, recovered after EGM and return
Best when	You have accumulated input credit, or thin cash	You have cash to fund the tax, or want a simpler paper trail

For most small exporters the LUT route is better, because it avoids paying tax you then have to chase. The IGST route is administratively simpler on the refund side - no formula, no computation, no deficiency memo - and it can be the right answer for a business with strong cash flow and weak accounting capacity.

What you cannot do is drift. The route must match across four places: the tax invoice, the shipping bill, GSTR-1 and GSTR-3B. A mismatch is the single most common reason a refund stalls, and it is entirely self-inflicted.

The tax invoice for an export

The invoice must state which route applies - supply meant for export on payment of integrated tax, or supply meant for export without payment of integrated tax under bond or Letter of Undertaking. It must carry the usual particulars, and its number and date must be the ones you report in GSTR-1 and quote on the shipping bill.

Three fields to lock before the invoice is raised: the invoice serial, the shipping bill number, date and port code that will be reported in table 6A, and whether the invoice is WPAY (with payment) or WOPAY (without payment). Choose wrongly and the data never reaches ICEGATE.

8. The LUT: file it before you ship, not after

A Letter of Undertaking, furnished in Form GST RFD-11 on the GST portal, is a binding undertaking to pay the tax due with interest if the conditions fail. It is filed once per financial year, is valid from 1 April to 31 March, and does not roll over.

- File it before the first zero-rated supply of the year. Practically, file it on 31 March or 1 April.
- The form auto-populates your GSTIN, legal name and address; you select the export type (goods, services, SEZ supplies) and give two witness details.
- Submission is by electronic verification code for proprietorships, partnerships and individuals; companies and LLPs need the authorised signatory's digital signature.

- The ARN is generated immediately and the LUT is deemed accepted on filing. No officer approval, no bond, no bank guarantee.
- Eligibility requires no prosecution for tax evasion of Rs. 250 lakh or more.

If the LUT lapses, the export invoice raised after 1 April without one carries a technical IGST liability. Officers have discretion to condone short gaps in genuine cases; relying on that discretion is not a system.

What rule 96A does if you break the undertaking

The consequences are specific and they run on two clocks.

- Goods: if the goods are not exported out of India within three months from the invoice date (or such further period as the Commissioner allows), you must pay the tax due with interest within fifteen days after that period expires.
- Services: if payment is not received within one year, or the period allowed under FEMA, whichever is later, the same fifteen-day rule applies.
- If you do not pay, the facility to export under bond or LUT is withdrawn forthwith and the amount is recovered as arrears. It is restored immediately when you pay.

9. The IGST route: your shipping bill is the refund claim

Under rule 96, the shipping bill filed by an exporter is deemed to be an application for refund of the integrated tax paid on the goods exported. There is no RFD-01, no formula, no computation sheet. That application is deemed filed only when two things happen: the person in charge of the conveyance files the export manifest covering that shipping bill, and you have furnished a valid return.

The five validations the system runs

Before the GST system transmits your export data to ICEGATE, it checks:

1. GSTR-1 and GSTR-3B for the period are both filed.
2. The export invoices appear in table 6A of GSTR-1.
3. Each invoice carries the correct shipping bill number, shipping bill date and six-character port code.
4. IGST and cess are reported in table 3.1(b) of GSTR-3B - not 3.1(a), not 3.1(c).
5. The IGST and cess in table 3.1(b) are equal to or greater than the total in tables 6A and 6B of GSTR-1.

Fail any one and the data is not sent to ICEGATE, and the refund does not happen. Nothing errors loudly. The refund simply sits.

Fixing a return you already filed

Incorrect or incomplete export invoices from a previous period can be amended through table 9A of GSTR-1 in a subsequent period. An invoice left out of table 6A can be reported in table 6A of a later return. Both are recoverable - but the recovery only starts when somebody compares the four documents, which is why the reconciliation below belongs in your monthly close, not in your year-end panic.

The monthly four-way match

Document	What it must agree on
Tax invoice	Invoice number, date, value, route, IGST amount
Shipping bill	Invoice number and date, FOB value, port, scheme codes

Document	What it must agree on
GSTR-1 table 6A	Same invoice number, shipping bill number, date, port code
GSTR-3B table 3.1(b)	IGST total at least equal to 6A plus 6B

10. The LUT route: RFD-01, the formula, and a worked example

Under the LUT route you have paid no IGST, so what you are refunding is the input tax credit that got consumed in making zero-rated supplies. That is claimed on Form GST RFD-01, with the computation in rule 89(4) of the CGST Rules.

The formula, exactly

Refund amount = (Turnover of zero-rated supply of goods + Turnover of zero-rated supply of services) x Net ITC / Adjusted total turnover.

- Net ITC means credit availed on inputs and input services during the relevant period.
- Turnover of zero-rated supply of goods is the value of zero-rated goods supplied without payment of tax under bond or LUT, or 1.5 times the value of like goods supplied domestically, whichever is less.
- Adjusted total turnover excludes the value of exempt supplies other than zero-rated supplies.
- For goods, the value used is the FOB value in the shipping bill or the value in the tax invoice, whichever is less.

Worked example

A garment exporter, one month. Domestic turnover Rs. 20,00,000. Export FOB value Rs. 80,00,000, all under LUT. Like goods sold domestically would have been valued at Rs. 95,00,000, so 1.5 times that is Rs. 1,42,50,000 - higher than the FOB value, so the FOB value of Rs. 80,00,000 is used. Net ITC availed during the month: Rs. 6,00,000.

Step	Amount
Zero-rated turnover of goods	Rs. 80,00,000
Adjusted total turnover (20,00,000 + 80,00,000)	Rs. 1,00,00,000
Net ITC	Rs. 6,00,000
Refund = 80,00,000 x 6,00,000 / 1,00,00,000	Rs. 4,80,000

The remaining Rs. 1,20,000 of credit is not lost - it stays in the electronic credit ledger, because it relates to the domestic turnover. That distinction matters when someone tells you the department 'kept' part of your refund.

Filing RFD-01 without a deficiency memo

- GSTR-1 and GSTR-3B must be filed for every period covered by the claim, before you file.
- The electronic credit ledger is debited by the amount claimed, at the time of filing.
- For goods, you need shipping bill and EGM details. For services, an FIRC or BRC for the inward remittance.
- Turnover of zero-rated supplies and adjusted total turnover are entered manually - the system cannot infer them.
- No rectification is allowed after filing. Check the values before you submit, not after.

- Note the ARN and track the application on the portal.

Two mistakes cause most deficiency memos: filing before the returns for the period are filed, and claiming on an export whose shipping bill or EGM is not yet visible to the system.

The deadlines, and what happens if they slip

The application must be made before the expiry of two years from the relevant date. For goods by sea or air, the relevant date is the date the ship or aircraft leaves India; by land, the date the goods cross the frontier; by post, the date of dispatch. For services paid after completion, it is the date the convertible foreign exchange is received; where payment came in advance, the invoice date.

If a refund is not sanctioned within the statutory time limit, interest on the delayed refund runs under section 56 of the CGST Act for the period of delay beyond sixty days. That is a right, not a favour, and it is worth asking for.

The 2026 refund reform

The refund mechanism was changed in 2026 in two phases, aimed at time-bound, automated processing. What changed, in the government's own summary:

- The time limit for an acknowledgement or a deficiency memo was cut from fifteen days to ten. If the officer does nothing in ten days, the application is deemed acknowledged and the acknowledgement is issued by the system.
- Provisional refund of up to 90 per cent of the amount claimed is sanctioned automatically by the system for acknowledged low-risk claims relating to zero-rated supplies or inverted duty structure.
- Final refund on account of a balance in the electronic cash ledger is sanctioned automatically.
- Deemed acknowledgement starts the processing clock - it does not mean automatic sanction.

Read that as a change in your own behaviour too. Ten days is short. A deficiency memo now arrives faster, and so does the point at which you are entitled to ask what happened.

PART 4

The money the government owes you

Three schemes return money to an exporter: RoDTEP for embedded taxes, duty drawback for duty paid on inputs, and the authorisation schemes that let you import inputs or capital goods without paying duty at all. They are separate. They can be claimed together in the right circumstances. And each has a deadline that people miss.

11. RoDTEP, and the 31 December 2026 deadline

The Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products scheme refunds embedded central, state and local duties, taxes and levies borne on the exported product, including prior-stage cumulative indirect taxes - the ones no other scheme refunds.

The scheme has been running on rolling extensions. The current position is unambiguous: DGFT notification 41/2026-27 dated 30 September 2026 continued RoDTEP up to 31 December 2026, at the rates and value caps notified in Appendices 4R and 4RE as they stood on 30 September 2026. The Department of Commerce announced the same extension publicly on 2 October 2026.

The date that matters

RoDTEP covers exports made up to 31 December 2026 under the current notification. It has been extended before and may be extended again, but no exporter should plan a margin on an extension that has not been notified. Ship before the year ends if the rebate is material to your price.

Who is covered

- Domestic tariff area units, using Appendix 4R rates.
- Advance Authorisation holders, export oriented units and SEZ units, using Appendix 4RE.
- Only goods. Services exports have no RoDTEP rate, because rates exist per HS code.
- Not available for duties and taxes already exempted, remitted or credited under another mechanism.

How the amount is calculated

The rebate is a notified percentage of FOB value, with a per-unit value cap for some items, and a fixed amount per unit for a few. For shipping bills filed on or after 1 October 2021, the system calculates it on the declared FOB value or up to 1.5 times the market price of the goods, whichever is less.

That 1.5-times rule is worth knowing if you sell to a group company below market price. The rebate is not computed on a transfer price the system considers unrealistic.

The 2026 rate churn, in one table

Notification	Date	What it did
60/2025-26	23 Feb 2026	Limited rates and value caps to 50 per cent with immediate effect
Corrigendum	24 Feb 2026	Excluded ITC-HS chapters 01 to 24 from that limitation
66/2025-26	23 Mar 2026	Restored the rates and caps applicable on 22 February 2026
74/2025-26	31 Mar 2026	Continued the scheme from 1 April to 30 September 2026
15/2026-27	30 Apr 2026	Aligned Appendices 4R and 4RE to tariff changes from 1 May 2026

Notification	Date	What it did
41/2026-27	30 Sep 2026	Continued the scheme to 31 December 2026 at unchanged rates

Why this matters: the rate that applies to a shipment is the one in force on the date of export. If you are reconciling last year's rebates, you cannot use today's schedule. And notification 15/2026-27 added 142 tariff lines, deleted 50 and changed two descriptions - so if your HS code changed in 2026, re-check the schedule before you assume your rate.

Claiming it: the declaration is everything

1. Confirm your eight-digit HS code appears in Appendix 4R or 4RE with a rate.
2. Register your IEC on ICEGATE with a digital signature certificate - the e-Scrip module requires it.
3. Declare the RoDTEP claim in the shipping bill when it is filed.
4. After the export general manifest is filed, customs processes the claim.
5. Customs generates a scroll listing the shipping bills and admissible amounts. It appears in your ICEGATE account.
6. Open e-Scrip, go to the credit ledger, and create an e-Scrip account under Add New Account.
7. Under Scrip Generation, select the shipping bills and generate the e-scrip. A credit entry is made in your ledger.

The e-scrip is a transferable duty credit. It can be used to pay basic customs duty on your own imports, or transferred to another IEC holder through Scrip Transfer. The transferee approves the request before the transfer completes, and the one-time password expires quickly. Status values include Active, Utilise, Transferred, Transfer Pending, Expired and Transfer Rejected - check expiry in the ledger, because an expired scrip is a write-off.

The clawback nobody reads

If export proceeds are not realised within the time allowed under FEMA, the RoDTEP rebate is deemed never to have been allowed. Customs can recover it, withhold or suspend it in cases of fraud or misuse, and impose penalties. The same logic applies to drawback.

This is why Part 5 of this book is not an afterthought. The incentive is conditional on realisation, not on shipment. An exporter who claims aggressively and collects slowly is building a liability, not a margin.

12. Duty drawback: all-industry rate or brand rate

Drawback, under section 75 of the Customs Act read with the Customs and Central Excise Duties Drawback Rules, 2017, refunds customs duty paid on inputs used to make the exported goods, and central excise duty on certain inputs still outside GST. It does not refund GST - that is the LUT or IGST route's job.

	All Industry Rate	Brand rate
Who sets it	Government, for the whole industry	Customs, for your product, on application
Basis	Average duty incidence across the industry	Your actual duty paid, with documents
When to use	Most exports	No rate exists, or the rate is under 80 per cent of duty paid
Effort	Declared on the shipping bill	Separate application with input-output data

The brand rate clock

A brand rate is fixed under rule 6 where no rate has been determined for the product, or under rule 7 where the determined rate is less than 80 per cent of the duties actually paid on the inputs. The application must be filed within three months from the relevant date - which is the first date of the let export order.

- An Assistant or Deputy Commissioner can extend by three months.
- The Principal Commissioner or Commissioner can extend by a further six months.
- The extension fee is 1 per cent of FOB value or Rs. 1,000, whichever is lower, at the first level; 2 per cent or Rs. 2,000 at the second.
- The fee is per application, not per shipping bill - CBIC clarified this in January 2025.
- A deficiency memo is issued within ten days for goods exported other than by post, and the claim is deemed not filed if deficiencies are not cured within thirty days.

The documents a brand rate application needs are the ones small exporters find hardest to assemble: drawback statements showing inputs, quantities and duty paid; bills of entry and purchase invoices for the inputs; the manufacturing process with input-output consumption; and copies of the shipping bills covered.

Which is the real argument for building that data monthly rather than annually. A manufacturer who can produce an input-output statement on demand gets a brand rate fixed in weeks. One who cannot spends the same weeks reconstructing invoices.

The service standards

CBIC's citizens' charter commits to sanction of drawback in three days from export where claims are processed electronically, fifteen days where processing is manual, and fixation of a brand rate within 25 days of a complete application. These are standards, not guarantees - but they are the numbers to quote when a claim goes quiet.

13. Advance Authorisation, EPCG, and status recognition

These are not refunds. They are permissions to import without paying duty, against a commitment to export. They are the biggest cash-flow tools available to a small manufacturer, and the most commonly misused.

Advance Authorisation

Advance Authorisation allows duty-free import of inputs that are physically incorporated in the export product, subject to a standard allowance for wastage, plus fuel, oil and catalysts consumed in the process. The authorisation carries an export obligation, and the clock is fixed: import validity is twelve months from issue, and the export obligation period is eighteen months from issue. One extension of up to six months is available on payment of composition fees; anything beyond that needs a further application and a self-declaration that unutilised inputs are still with you.

The trap is arithmetic, not paperwork. If you take the authorisation and the order is cancelled, the obligation survives the order.

EPCG

The Export Promotion Capital Goods scheme allows import of capital goods at zero customs duty - and, for physical exports, exemption from IGST and compensation cess as well. The conditions:

- Export obligation equal to six times the duties, taxes and cess saved, to be fulfilled in six years from the date of authorisation.
- An average export obligation that must be met every financial year until the obligation is completed.
- The authorisation is valid for imports for twenty-four months, and revalidation is not permitted.
- Indigenous sourcing of capital goods carries a specific obligation 25 per cent lower.
- Green technology products get 75 per cent of the standard obligation; units in the north-east and in Jammu and Kashmir, and Ladakh, get 25 per cent.

EPCG is a six-year commitment. Before signing, model the average export obligation against your last three years of actual exports, not against your hopes for the next six.

Status recognition, and the small-exporter thresholds

Status holders get recognition, and with it administrative conveniences - self-ratification of norms for two-star and above, for example. Under FTP 2023 the thresholds were cut sharply, which brought far more firms in:

Category	Export performance (USD million)
One Star Export House	3
Two Star Export House	15
Three Star Export House	50
Four Star Export House	200
Five Star Export House	800

Since 2023 the certificate is system-generated every August from Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics merchandise export data. You do not apply. Roughly 20,000 exporters are recognised, against 12,518 under the earlier system - most of the increase in the one-star category, which needs USD 3 million.

RCMC: the Rs. 3 lakh exemption

A Registration-cum-Membership Certificate from the relevant export promotion council is required for various scheme benefits. From 15 September 2026, DGFT notification 36/2026-27 exempted consignments with an FOB value not exceeding Rs. 3,00,000 from the RCMC requirement, where it would otherwise apply.

Three things to be clear about. The threshold is per export consignment, not annual turnover. Consignments above Rs. 3 lakh still need a valid RCMC wherever the policy requires one. And the exemption removes only the RCMC - not the IEC, not GST, not customs, not product licences, not destination-country requirements.

The government's own data explains the policy: consignments up to USD 3,000 account for 43 per cent of India's shipping bills but only 0.86 per cent of merchandise export value. The exemption is aimed squarely at the long tail of small shipments.

PART 5

Getting paid, and proving it

This is where Indian exporters lose the most money without noticing. The shipment is done, the buyer is happy, the payment arrived - and the entry is still open, the eBRC is not generated, and the incentives claimed on that shipment are technically recoverable.

14. FEMA 2026: nine months, and what happens after

From 1 October 2026 a single set of regulations governs exports and imports of goods and services: the Foreign Exchange Management (Export and Import of Goods and Services) Regulations, 2026, notified on 13 January 2026 and amended twice since. It replaced the 2015 export regulations, both master directions and a long list of circulars.

If you read a guide written between January and September 2026, it probably quotes fifteen months. That was the position for part of the year and it is no longer the position.

The realisation clock

Export	Period allowed
Goods, from date of shipment	9 months
Services, from date of invoice	9 months
Goods sold from an overseas warehouse, from date of sale	9 months
Project exports	As per the payment terms of the contract
Any of the above, invoiced or settled in Indian rupees	12 months

The authorised dealer may extend the period on your request, citing reasons, if it is satisfied with them. That extension is a bank decision, not an RBI application, and it is the first tool to reach for when a buyer asks for more time.

Reduction in realisation

Under regulation 6, the authorised dealer may allow a reduction in realisation on your request, where the reasons for under-realisation or non-realisation satisfy it. Where the export value is up to Rs. 10 lakh per shipping bill for goods, or per invoice for services, the reduction - including non-realisation of the full value - may be permitted on the basis of a declaration from you.

That Rs. 10 lakh declaration route is the practical answer to the most common small shortfall: bank charges, intermediary deductions and small discounts that leave the realised amount a few per cent below the shipping bill value. Close them with a declaration rather than leaving the entry open for nine months.

Set-off

Regulation 7 allows set-off of export receivables against import payables with the same overseas buyer or supplier, or with their overseas group or associate companies, within the realisation period or any extension allowed. If you both buy from and sell to the same group, this is a legitimate way to close two entries at once - with the bank's approval and proper reporting.

Regulation 13: the consequence that stops your business

If export proceeds remain unrealised beyond one year from the due date of realisation, or any extended period allowed, further exports are permitted only against receipt of full advance or an irrevocable letter of credit.

Read that again, because it is the harshest rule in this book. One large overdue receivable can end your ability to ship on open account. Not a penalty, not a fine - a change in the terms on which you are allowed to trade.

15. eBRC and closing the loop in EDPMS

The electronic Bank Realisation Certificate is DGFT's proof that a specific export was paid for. It used to be a certificate you requested from your bank branch and waited for. It is now something you generate yourself, free, from data your bank has already sent.

How the loop works

1. Your bank receives foreign currency and records an inward remittance.
2. The bank transmits an Inward Remittance Message to DGFT electronically. You cannot edit an IRM; you can only map it.
3. You log in to the DGFT portal, open the IRM repository, and match the remittance to the shipping bill, SOFTEX form or export invoice it belongs to.
4. You self-certify the eBRC. It is stored in the DGFT repository and visible to banks and regional authorities.
5. In parallel, your bank closes the corresponding shipping bill entry in EDPMS against the same remittance.

The self-certification system is described in DGFT Trade Notice 33/2023-24. The portal services are the IRM and ORM repository, eBRC generation, viewing and cancelling an unutilised eBRC, and a utilisation report linking remittances to shipping bills and invoices.

The purpose code rules that block people

- Only IRMs of the same currency can be clubbed.
- Only IRMs from the same bank can be clubbed.
- eBRCs cannot be generated for purpose codes P0101 and P0108.
- P0103 (advance payment) can be used standalone, and can be clubbed with any other purpose code.
- No two other purpose codes can be combined into one eBRC.
- For services in the IT category, only P0802, P0803, P0807 and P0103 apply.
- One shipping bill can be used across two or more eBRCs from different banks.

For services exporters there is an extra field: the mode of export of services, mandatory in the eBRC format since Trade Notice 02/2025-26.

Why shipping bills stay open

Five reasons, in the order they occur:

1. Part payments, or one payment covering several invoices, that the bank cannot match line by line.
2. Bank charges or discounts deducted abroad, leaving the realised amount below the shipping bill value - which needs a reduction approved by the AD bank.

3 The wrong AD code or IEC on the shipping bill, so the entry sits with a bank that never receives the payment.

4 Third-party or netted payments that do not clearly reference the export.

5 No link in your own records between the customer invoice, the shipping bill number and the incoming payment, so nobody sees what is still open until the deadline.

Only the fifth is fully in your control, and it is the one that causes the others to go unnoticed. Record the shipping bill number and date against every export invoice, and age open receivables against the realisation date rather than against payment terms.

16. Services exports: the same clock, different paperwork

Half of India's export businesses sell services, not goods: IT support, design, consulting, accounting, marketing, engineering. The FEMA rules for realisation are identical. Almost everything else is different, and from 1 October 2026 the declaration itself changed.

SOFTEX is gone; one form covers everything

Under the 2026 Regulations, software is treated as a service, and the separate SOFTEX form has been discontinued. A single Export Declaration Form now covers exports of goods, services and software. The definition of software is broad - any computer programme, database, drawing, design, audio or video signal, or information, in or on any medium other than a physical one.

Export	Who receives the EDF	When
Goods	Commissioner of Customs (DTA) or Development Commissioner (SEZ)	At the time of export; at EDI ports it is deemed part of the shipping bill
Services other than software	Authorised Dealer bank (DTA) or Development Commissioner (SEZ)	On or before the date of receipt of payment
Software	Authorised Dealer bank or STPI (DTA), or Development Commissioner (SEZ)	Within 30 days from the end of the month in which the invoice is raised

Three practical points sit inside that table. A service exporter may file one EDF covering all exports to one or more recipients in a month. The authorised dealer may extend the filing period on request, if satisfied with the reason. And the bank must enter the EDF details in EDPMS within five working days of receiving them, which is why a services entry shows up in the system faster than it used to.

The most useful of these is the deemed-submission rule for resident individuals, and the Rs. 10 lakh threshold for everyone else: where the exporter gives the bank the information it needs to credit the payment, the EDF is treated as submitted. For a freelancer invoicing USD 2,000 a month, the paperwork is the bank credit itself.

The GST side is stricter than people assume

Export of services is zero-rated, but 'export of services' has statutory conditions, and all of them must be met: the supplier is located in India, the place of supply is outside India, the payment is received in convertible foreign exchange or in Indian rupees where the RBI permits it, and the supplier and recipient are not merely establishments of a distinct person.

Fail any one and the supply is not an export. It is a domestic supply with GST on it. The three failures seen most often: invoicing in rupees but receiving in dollars (or the reverse) without the RBI permission

that makes rupee settlement valid; a group company abroad that is a branch of the Indian entity; and payment received by an unrelated third party without documentation.

The refund clock for services

For the LUT route, the relevant date for the two-year refund window is the date of receipt of the convertible foreign exchange where the service was completed before payment, and the invoice date where payment was received in advance. The RFD-01 for services needs an FIRC or a bank realisation certificate for the inward remittance - the goods route does not.

Under rule 96A, if payment for services is not received within one year, or the period allowed under FEMA, whichever is later, the tax and interest become payable within fifteen days after that period expires. The one-year rule does not replace the FEMA clock; the later of the two governs.

Purpose codes, and why they decide whether you can claim

Every inward remittance carries a purpose code. For IT and IT-enabled services the relevant codes are P0802, P0803, P0807 and P0103 - and DGFT's eBRC rules allow only those four for the IT category. Advance payment, P0103, is the flexible one: it can be used standalone and clubbed with any other purpose code.

- eBRCs cannot be generated against P0101 and P0108 at all.
- Only remittances in the same currency, from the same bank, can be clubbed.
- For services, the eBRC format carries a mandatory mode of export of services field.
- Invoices attached to a services eBRC must have SAC codes matching the service described.

This is the point where service exporters lose incentive claims: the bank coded the payment as something else, and no amount of explaining changes the code. Fix it with the bank at the time of remittance, not at the time of claim.

The services calendar

When	What
Invoice date	LUT live; place of supply outside India; currency stated
Within 30 days of month end	EDF for software exports filed with the AD bank or STPI
On or before receipt	EDF for other services filed
At receipt	Purpose code correct; FIRC obtained; IRM visible in the DGFT repository
Month end	GSTR-1 table 6A; GSTR-3B; four-way match
Monthly	eBRC self-certified; EDPMS entry closed
Month 9	Realisation deadline from invoice date (12 months if invoiced in rupees)
Month 24	GST refund window closes, measured from the relevant date

17. When payment goes wrong

A buyer who stops paying is not only a commercial problem. It triggers consequences in four separate systems: FEMA, GST, RoDTEP and drawback. Handle them in this order.

Step 1: ask the bank to extend

Before the nine months run out, write to your authorised dealer with the reasons and a revised expected date. An extension keeps the entry legitimate. Doing nothing does not.

Step 2: if the shortfall is small, use the declaration route

Up to Rs. 10 lakh per shipping bill, a reduction in realisation can be permitted on your declaration. This is designed for exactly the case of charges and discounts.

Step 3: understand the GST consequence

Where you took a refund of unutilised input credit on zero-rated goods and the sale proceeds are not realised, section 16(3) of the IGST Act requires you to deposit the refund received, with interest under section 50 of the CGST Act, within thirty days after the expiry of the time limit prescribed under FEMA for receipt of foreign exchange.

Thirty days. Not thirty days from when you notice - thirty days from the FEMA deadline. This is the single most overlooked deadline in export compliance, and it converts a bad debt into a tax demand.

Step 4: the incentive recovery

RoDTEP is deemed never to have been allowed if proceeds are not realised in time. Drawback is recoverable under rule 18 of the Drawback Rules, 2017 on the same trigger. Both are mechanical consequences of an open entry, not discretionary penalties.

What to do with the receivable itself

- Document the commercial efforts: reminders, the buyer's responses, any settlement proposal. Banks ask for this and so does an auditor.
- If the buyer is insolvent, get the evidence - the liquidation notice, the court filing. It is the strongest basis for a reduction or write-off request.
- Do not simply stop shipping and stop reporting. An unreported overdue entry becomes a caution-listing issue and then a regulation 13 problem.
- If the amount is material, take advice on compounding under FEMA. It is a route, not a disaster, but it is a legal step, not a paperwork step.

The one habit that prevents most of this

A monthly meeting with one screen: every open shipping bill, its value, its realisation due date, and its status in EDPMS. Fifteen minutes. It replaces the annual discovery that four entries from last year are still open.

PART 6

Channels, mistakes, and the calendar

The rules changed sharply for small shipments in 2026. Two reforms - one at customs, one at DGFT - made courier and e-commerce exports viable for businesses that would never have afforded a container. Then a third created a framework for holding inventory abroad.

18. Courier and e-commerce exports after the 2026 reforms

From 1 April 2026 the Rs. 10 lakh value cap per consignment for commercial exports through courier was removed. DGFT did it by amending para 9.05 of FTP 2023 in notification 67/2025-26 dated 27 March 2026. CBIC did the customs side through Circular 17/2026-Customs and amendments to the courier regulations, notified as 33/2026-Customs (N.T.) and 34/2026-Customs (N.T.).

The cap was the reason a growing seller had to divert shipments to air or sea cargo purely because of value. That reason is gone, and it applies to non-e-commerce commercial goods through courier as well, not only to marketplace parcels.

The two other reforms in the same package

- A Return to Origin facility for imports: goods left uncleared or unclaimed for more than fifteen days, and not prohibited, restricted or under enforcement hold, can be returned to origin under a simplified procedure.
- A risk-based framework for re-importing returned or rejected goods, replacing consignment-wise verification, with a dedicated return module in the express cargo clearance system.

For an e-commerce exporter, returns are not an exception - they are a cost line. A return module with a defined procedure is worth more than a marginally lower freight rate.

What still applies

Courier mode is not a shortcut around export law. Exports through a registered courier service or foreign post office remain subject to the notifications under the Customs Act, and exportability is still governed by the ITC(HS) export policy. What changed is the value ceiling, not the compliance floor.

19. The inventory-based framework, decoded

On 5 August 2026 DGFT created a structure for the model that global marketplaces use: hold Indian goods in an overseas warehouse, sell from there, and ship to the buyer locally. Notification 27/2026-27 inserted the substantive framework into FTP 2023, and Public Notice 25/2026-27 set out the procedure and the registration form, ANF-9A.

The two roles

Role	What it is
Exporter-on-Record	An entity with a valid IEC and GSTIN, registered with DGFT under the framework, which buys from sellers and exports in its own name
Seller-on-Record	A GST-registered Indian entity supplying goods to the Exporter-on-Record against the EOR's confirmed export orders
Export Inventory	Goods bought against a confirmed export order and held exclusively for export, traceable as export-designated stock

The rules that decide whether it works for you

- Only goods of Indian origin are eligible, and the seller is responsible for declaring origin correctly.
- Title passes from seller to exporter only against a confirmed export order from a buyer outside India. Speculative inventory build-up is not permitted.
- The exporter must pay the seller promptly on acceptance, and in any event within seven days - and that payment cannot be made conditional on receiving money from the overseas buyer.
- Export rebates and refunds must be apportioned among sellers in proportion to the FOB value of each seller's goods as declared in the shipping bill.
- The exporter may retain an administrative charge, capped at 10 per cent of the gross export rebates and refunds.
- Seller-attributable benefits must be disbursed within thirty days of the exporter receiving them.
- The exporter owns reverse logistics for returned or rejected consignments, and those goods must not be sold in the domestic market.
- Notified E-Commerce Export Hubs must be used to the extent practicable.

The seven-day payment rule is the one that decides feasibility. If you are the Exporter-on-Record, you are funding inventory and paying suppliers before you are paid. That is a working capital business, not a paperwork business - and it is worth being honest about that before registering.

There is also a corporate structure condition: an e-commerce entity proposing to undertake these operations must do so through a separate legal entity incorporated for the purpose, and must disclose its shareholding and control relationship at registration.

20. Records, notices, and the file you can defend

An export claim is only as good as the file behind it. The law sets a retention period, and the period is longer than most small businesses assume.

How long to keep what

Under section 36 of the CGST Act, books of account and other records must be retained until the expiry of seventy-two months from the due date for furnishing the annual return for the year to which they relate. If you are party to an appeal, revision or other proceeding, or under investigation for an offence, the records on that subject must be kept for one year after final disposal, or the ordinary period, whichever is later.

Note the starting point: it is the due date of the annual return, not the transaction date. In practice that means a shipment made in April 2026 sits in your obligation until roughly December 2033.

Rule 56(1) of the CGST Rules separately requires accounts of goods and services exported, supported by documents - and names the shipping bills, the LUT or bond, and bank realisation or foreign inward remittance certificates among them.

The per-consignment file

One folder per shipping bill, physical or digital, containing:

1. Commercial invoice and packing list, in the final version filed.
2. GST tax invoice, matching the GSTR-1 entry.
3. Purchase order, contract or letter of credit.
4. Shipping bill, final digitally signed copy with the LEO endorsement.

5 Bill of lading or airway bill, and the EGM reference.

6 e-Sanchit IRN list for the documents uploaded.

7 Scheme documents: LUT acknowledgement, authorisation, RoDTEP or drawback declaration.

8 Proof of realisation: bank credit advice, FIRC, IRM reference, eBRC number.

9 Correspondence with the buyer on any shortfall, discount or claim.

That folder answers almost every question a GST officer, a customs auditor or a bank can ask about that shipment, because every question is a version of 'show me that these four documents agree'.

What an export notice usually asks

Notices on export refunds are rarely about the law. They are about evidence: prove the goods left India, prove the invoice was reported, prove the tax was paid or the LUT was valid, prove the money came back. The four-way match in Chapter 9 is the same evidence, assembled monthly.

- Answer with documents, in the order asked, and with a one-page chronology.
- Never send a document that contradicts another one you have already sent. Reconcile first.
- If an entry is genuinely wrong, say so and quantify the correction. An admitted small error is cheaper than a defended large one.
- Keep the reply and the acknowledgement in the same folder as the shipment.

The commercial version of the same advice: if your records can produce the four-way match in an hour, your refunds move faster even before anyone asks, because the deficiency memo rate falls. Reconciliation is not an audit chore. It is a cash-flow tool.

21. Fifteen mistakes that cost small exporters money

#	Mistake	What it costs, and the fix
1	IEC not updated between April and June	Filing blocked at the worst moment. Calendar it on 1 April.
2	AD code registered at the wrong port	Shipping bill rejected at filing. Register per port, per bank.
3	Six-digit HS code	Rejection, wrong duty for the buyer, wrong RoDTEP rate. Verify eight digits per product.
4	Product description typed three times, three ways	Automated mismatch and a hold. Write it once, copy it everywhere.
5	LUT not filed for the new financial year	Technical IGST liability plus interest. File by 31 March.
6	Route mismatch between invoice, shipping bill and returns	Refund stalls indefinitely. Lock the route before invoicing.
7	IGST shown in table 3.1(a) instead of 3.1(b)	Data never reaches ICEGATE. Correct the return, then re-file.
8	RoDTEP not declared at filing	Post-EGM amendment is, in practice, a court matter. Declare it.
9	EGM never checked	Refund and e-scrip both sit. It is the first diagnostic.
10	Shipping bill left open in EDPMS for a small shortfall	Open entry ages into a realisation problem. Use the Rs. 10 lakh declaration route.
11	Incentives claimed on shipments that never get paid	RoDTEP deemed never allowed; drawback recoverable. Match claims to collections.

#	Mistake	What it costs, and the fix
12	GST refund deposit missed after non-realisation	Thirty days from the FEMA deadline, with interest. Diarise it.
13	Brand rate application filed after three months	Extension fees, or a lost claim. File within three months of the first LEO date.
14	eBRC never generated	Incentive claims and proofs missing. Self-certify monthly, free.
15	No single owner for compliance	Everything above happens once and recurs. Name one person and one monthly review.

22. The calendar: day 0 to day 270

Export compliance is not a set of tasks. It is a schedule. This is the schedule for a single consignment on open account terms.

When	What must be true
Day -10	IEC updated, LUT filed for the year, AD code registered at this port, HS code verified, invoice description finalised
Day -5	Commercial invoice, packing list and GST invoice issued with matching numbers and values; documents uploaded to e-Sanchit
Day -2	Shipping bill filed with the correct route, scheme codes and RoDTEP declaration; checklist read line by line
Day 0	Assessment complete, goods examined if selected, LEO issued, goods loaded
Day 1-3	Export general manifest filed by the carrier; shipping bill visible in EDPMS; check it
Day 5-10	GSTR-1 filed with table 6A entries matching the shipping bill exactly
Day 15-20	GSTR-3B filed with IGST in table 3.1(b); four-way match completed
Day 20-30	IGST refund credited, or RFD-01 filed for the LUT route
Day 30-60	RoDTEP scroll appears; e-scrip generated; drawback sanctioned if claimed
Payment date	Remittance received, IRM appears in the DGFT repository, eBRC self-certified, EDPMS entry closed
Month 8	Any unreceived payment flagged; extension request to the AD bank
Month 9	FEMA deadline. If unreceived and unextended, the GST refund deposit clock starts at 30 days
Month 12	Any entry still open beyond a year from the due date means further exports only against advance or irrevocable LC

Print this page. Put the dates against your own consignment. Most of the failures described in this book are a missed row on this table, discovered months later.

APPENDIX

One consignment, start to finish

A worked example with round numbers, to show how the parts interact. The figures are illustrative and are not a rate quotation - rates for RoDTEP, drawback and IGST depend on your product and the date of export.

The shipment

Item	Value
Product	1,200 cotton knitted T-shirts, HS 6109
Buyer terms	CIF Rotterdam, 30 days credit
FOB value	Rs. 20,00,000
Freight	Rs. 1,10,000
Insurance	Rs. 9,000
CIF invoice value	Rs. 21,19,000
Domestic turnover, same month	Rs. 30,00,000
Net ITC for the month	Rs. 1,50,000

Under CIF the seller arranges and pays freight and insurance, and provides the insurance certificate with the documents. Under FOB the buyer does. Under CIP the seller must insure on wider terms than CIF requires. Which term you sell on decides which of these documents you must produce, so it belongs in the order confirmation, not in the invoice footnote.

The paperwork, in order

Day	Action	Record created
-10	IEC updated, LUT filed, AD code registered at Mumbai port	e-IEC, LUT ARN, AD code letter
-6	HS 6109 verified in ITC(HS), Appendix 4R and the drawback schedule	Classification log row
-4	Commercial invoice and packing list issued, description locked	Invoice, packing list
-4	GST invoice issued under LUT	Tax invoice with LUT reference
-2	Documents uploaded to e-Sanchit; shipping bill filed with RoDTEP and drawback declared	IRNs, shipping bill number
0	Assessment, examination waived, LEO issued, container loaded	LEO
2	EGM filed by the line	EGM reference
7	GSTR-1 filed; table 6A carries the shipping bill number, date and port code	GSTR-1
18	GSTR-3B filed; four-way match complete	GSTR-3B
25	RFD-01 filed for the LUT route refund	ARN
40	RoDTEP scroll appears; e-scrip generated	e-scrip credit

Day	Action	Record created
55	Drawback sanctioned	Bank credit
30 days after shipment	Payment received; IRM matched; eBRC self-certified; EDPMS closed	eBRC number

The money

Head	Calculation	Amount
GST refund (LUT route)	20,00,000 x 1,50,000 / 50,00,000	Rs. 60,000
RoDTEP (illustrative 1.2% of FOB)	1.2% x 20,00,000	Rs. 24,000
Drawback (illustrative 2% of FOB)	2% x 20,00,000	Rs. 40,000
Total recovered		Rs. 1,24,000
As a share of FOB value	1,24,000 / 20,00,000	6.2%

Six per cent of invoice value is not a rounding error. It is the difference between a viable export price and one that loses money quietly.

The same shipment, done three ways

Variant	What happens	Cost
Everything done as above	All three recoveries land	Rs. 1,24,000 recovered
RoDTEP not declared at filing	No e-scrip; post-EGM amendment is a court route in practice	Rs. 24,000 lost
IGST route instead of LUT	Rs. 1,00,000 IGST paid at 5 per cent and refunded after EGM and return	Cash blocked roughly 30-45 days; no formula, no deficiency memo
Invoice description differs between documents	Query at assessment; amendment before LEO	Two to five days of demurrage risk
Payment arrives 20 per cent short, no declaration filed	Entry open in EDPMS; RoDTEP technically recoverable	Rs. 24,000 at risk plus a compliance problem

Every row in that table is a choice made in the ten days before the container moves. None of them can be fixed cheaply afterwards. That is the whole argument for this book: the paperwork is not administration that follows the export, it is the thing that determines what the export is worth.

WORKSHEETS

Worksheet 1: the per-shipment document checklist

One sheet per consignment. Tick only what exists in final, signed, PDF form.

Done	Document	Checked against
[ ]	Commercial invoice	Description identical to packing list
[ ]	Packing list (or combined invoice-cum-list)	Package count and weights
[ ]	GST tax invoice	Number and date match GSTR-1

Done	Document	Checked against
[ ]	Purchase order / contract / LC	Value and terms
[ ]	Bill of lading or airway bill	Consignee and port
[ ]	Certificate of origin, if required	Destination rules
[ ]	Product licence or certificate	ITC(HS) conditions
[ ]	Advance Authorisation / EPCG, if claimed	Scheme reference
[ ]	Insurance, if CIF terms	Value
[ ]	e-Sanchit IRNs noted	Quoted in the shipping bill

Worksheet 2: twenty checks before you approve the shipping bill

#	Check
1	IEC is active and updated for this financial year
2	GSTIN is the one that issued the tax invoice
3	AD code is registered at this specific port
4	HS code is eight digits and verified this year
5	Product description matches the invoice word for word
6	Quantity, packages, gross and net weight agree across documents
7	FOB value equals the invoice value, in the same currency
8	Export route (LUT or IGST) matches the tax invoice
9	Invoice number and date match GSTR-1 table 6A
10	Port code is the six-character code for this port
11	RoDTEP is declared, or deliberately not claimed
12	Drawback serial number is correct, if claimed
13	Scheme codes match the authorisation in hand
14	Third-party exporter details included, if applicable
15	All e-Sanchit IRNs are attached to the items
16	Buyer name and address match the order
17	Country of destination is correct
18	Marks and numbers on packages match the packing list
19	Any restricted-goods condition satisfied
20	A named person has read this checklist, not just the broker

Worksheet 3: GST refund tracker

Period	Route	Claimed	ARN / SB	Status	Next action

Status values worth using consistently: filed, acknowledged, deficiency memo, provisionally sanctioned, sanctioned, interest due. Anything sitting in deficiency memo for more than thirty days needs a written follow-up, not another portal refresh.

Worksheet 4: realisation tracker

Shipping bill	Value	Shipment date	Due date	Received	EDPMS status

Due date is nine months from shipment, or twelve if invoiced in rupees. Sort by due date, not by value. The entry closest to its deadline is the one that can stop your next shipment.

Worksheet 5: HS code verification log

Product	8-digit code	Verified on	Source	RoDTEP rate

Re-verify any row older than twelve months, and every row immediately after a change in grade, composition, processing or packaging.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
AD code	Authorised Dealer code: the bank branch code through which export proceeds are received, registered at a customs port
AIR	All Industry Rate of duty drawback, set for a product class
ANF	Aayaat Niryaat Form: the DGFT application forms, such as ANF-2A for IEC and ANF-9A for Exporter-on-Record registration
Brand rate	A drawback rate fixed for a specific exporter's product on application
Drawback	Refund of customs duty paid on inputs used in exported goods
eBRC	Electronic Bank Realisation Certificate: self-certified proof that an export was paid for
EDF	Export Declaration Form: the single declaration for exports of goods, services and software from 1 October 2026
EDPMS	Export Data Processing and Monitoring System, RBI's record of exports and their realisation
EGM	Export General Manifest, filed by the carrier, which completes the export in customs systems
e-IEC	The electronic Importer-Exporter Code issued by DGFT
EOR	Exporter-on-Record under the inventory-based e-commerce framework
EPCG	Export Promotion Capital Goods scheme: zero-duty import of capital goods against an export obligation
e-Sanchit	The ICEGATE facility for uploading supporting documents and generating IRNs
FEMA	Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999, and the regulations made under it
FOB	Free on Board: the value of goods at the port of shipment, excluding freight and insurance
FTP	Foreign Trade Policy; the 2023 policy remains in force with amendments
HS code	Harmonised System classification; India uses eight digits in ITC-HS
ICEGATE	Indian Customs Electronic Gateway, the portal for shipping bills, bills of entry and e-scrips
IEC	Importer-Exporter Code, issued by DGFT against a PAN
IRM	Inward Remittance Message, transmitted by banks to DGFT
IRN	Image Reference Number generated for each document uploaded to e-Sanchit
ITC-HS	India's tariff classification schedule, aligned to the HS
LEO	Let Export Order, the customs clearance that permits loading
LUT	Letter of Undertaking in Form GST RFD-11, allowing export without payment of IGST
Net ITC	Input tax credit availed on inputs and input services in the relevant period
RCMC	Registration-cum-Membership Certificate from an export promotion council
RFD-01	The GST refund application form
RoDTEP	Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products
RoSCTL	Scheme for remission of state and central taxes on textiles and apparel

Term	Meaning
SOR	Seller-on-Record under the inventory-based e-commerce framework
SOFTEX	The earlier declaration form for software exports, discontinued and replaced by the single EDF
Zero-rated	A supply taxed at zero per cent, with input credit refundable

Sources

Every rule in this book is traceable to a primary document. These are the ones to check first when a rate, a date or a threshold changes.

- DGFT: Foreign Trade Policy 2023 and Handbook of Procedures 2023, Chapter 2 (IEC, paras 2.08 to 2.15), Chapter 5 (EPCG), Chapter 9 (courier and e-commerce exports).
- DGFT notifications cited: 58/2015-20 (IEC annual updation), 67/2025-26 (courier value limit removed), 36/2026-27 (RCMC exemption up to Rs. 3 lakh), 27/2026-27 (inventory-based e-commerce framework), 60/2025-26, 66/2025-26, 74/2025-26, 15/2026-27 and 41/2026-27 (RoDTEP rates and continuation).
- DGFT Public Notice 25/2026-27 (procedure and ANF-9A under the e-commerce framework); Trade Notice 33/2023-24 (eBRC self-certification); Trade Notice 02/2025-26 (mode of export of services in eBRC).
- DGFT: eBRC self-certification guidelines on dgft.gov.in, including the purpose code clubbing rules; RoDTEP schedule Appendices 4R and 4RE.
- RBI: A.P. (DIR Series) Circular No. 20 dated 16 January 2026, and the EDF, specified authority and reporting provisions of the 2026 Regulations (regulations 2, 3, 5, 6, 7, 13 and 18).
- CBIC: Customs Act, 1962, sections 50, 75, 149; Customs and Central Excise Duties Drawback Rules, 2017, rules 3, 6, 7, 12, 14 and 18.
- CBIC: Circular 17/2026-Customs and notifications 33/2026-Customs (N.T.) and 34/2026-Customs (N.T.) on courier and e-commerce reform; citizens' charter service standards for drawback.
- CBIC: CGST Rules, 2017, rules 89, 89(4) and 96A; CGST Act, 2017, sections 54 and 56; IGST Act, 2017, section 16.
- CBIC and GSTN: refund user guides for export of goods with and without payment of tax; PIB FAQ on the 2026 refund mechanism changes (9 October 2026).
- ICEGATE: e-Sanchit FAQs and the e-Scrip advisory for RoSCTL and RoDTEP; customs advisories on the post-EGM amendment module (Advisory 16/2025).
- RBI: Foreign Exchange Management (Export and Import of Goods and Services) Regulations, 2026, Notification No. FEMA 23(R)/2026-RB dated 13 January 2026, as amended up to 2 November 2026 - regulations 5, 6, 7 and 13.
- RBI: FEMA notifications 23(R)/(1)/2026-RB dated 22 September 2026 and 23(R)/(2)/2026-RB dated 2 November 2026 (nine-month and twelve-month realisation periods).
- PIB: releases of 2 October 2026 (RoDTEP extension), 16 September 2026 (RCMC exemption), 31 March 2026 (courier and e-commerce reforms) and 9 October 2026 (refund mechanism FAQs).
- The Economic Times, 23 February 2026: reporting on export paperwork delays, quoting FIEO, FISME and Laghu Udyog Bharti estimates.

This playbook is a working guide, not legal or tax advice. Customs, GST and FEMA positions change by notification. Before acting on a specific consignment, check the current text on dgft.gov.in, cbic.gov.in, icegate.gov.in and rbi.org.in, and take professional advice where the amount at stake justifies it.